

Hieroglyphs

The ancient Egyptians wrote using a series of stylized pictures, called hieroglyphs. In tombs, they were used to write stories about a person's life and family. Inscriptions in Khufukhaf's tomb explain that he was the vizier (prime minister) of Egypt and the son of a queen.

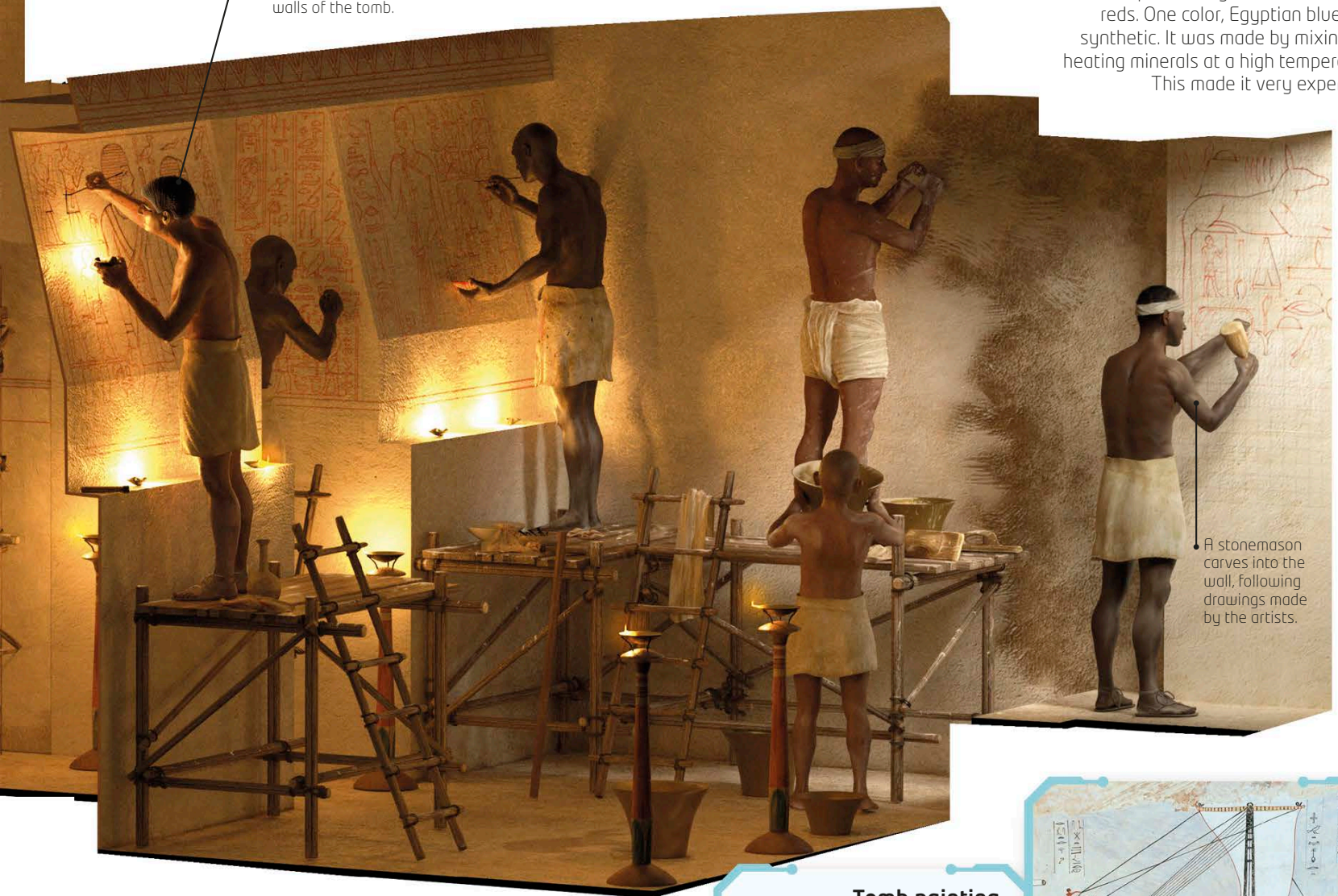


Skilled artists sketch out images onto the freshly plastered walls of the tomb.



Painting materials

Ancient Egyptian paintbrushes were bundles of grasses or reeds tied together with string. Most paint was made from natural rock pigments—for example, iron oxide produced yellows, ochers, and reds. One color, Egyptian blue, was synthetic. It was made by mixing and heating minerals at a high temperature. This made it very expensive.



A stonemason carves into the wall, following drawings made by the artists.

Mastaba come from the Arabic word for "**bench**" because these **tombs** were **bench-shaped**.

Tomb painting

Painting tomb walls with images such as this boat on the Nile was often a lengthy process. Craftsmen plastered the walls and artists drew the outlines, adding color at the end.

